You can cook the apples—skin, core, and all—as you will be sieving the end result. For special occasions, use dry sherry or white wine instead of water.

pumpkin and apple soup

SERVES 6 **PREP** 20 MINS **COOK** 40 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS

4 tbsp unsalted butter
1 medium onion, finely chopped
7oz (200g) pumpkin flesh, diced
2 sharp-tasting apples such as Granny Smith, diced
½ cup hot water
4 cups cold vegetable stock or chicken stock
salt and freshly ground black pepper
2 tsp toasted pumpkin seeds, to garnish

1 Melt the butter in a large saucepan, add the onion, and cook very gently, stirring often, for 10 minutes or until soft. Do not let it brown. Add the pumpkin and apples and stir to coat well. Pour in the hot water, cover with a lid, and leave on a very, very low heat for 30 minutes, stirring from time to time. If the liquid evaporates, pour in a little more hot water. The vegetables and fruit should be very soft at the end of cooking.

2 Stir in the stock, then blend the soup in batches. As each batch is done, pour it into a sieve set over a clean saucepan. Press the contents through with the back of a ladle, a wooden spoon, or a pestle.

3 When all the soup has been sieved, reheat it very gently, then season to taste with salt and freshly ground black pepper. Serve garnished with the toasted pumpkin seeds.